CHINA'S FIBER FOOTPRINT

How PEACE, DARE, & Huawei Cable Network Are Building Beijing's Intelligence Architecture Across Africa

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70%	60%	90+	$10T
Africa's 4G Infrastructure Runs on Huawei	Global Cable Market Target China's DSR by end of 2025	HMN Tech cable project globally since 2008	Daily Data Flow at Stake (Money transfersvia cables)

Beneath the ocean floor, a quiet contest is playing out that will determine who controls the arteries of the global internet for decades.

China's Digital Silk Road, executed through state-owned carriers China Mobile, China Telecom, and China Unicom, cable manufacturer and layer HMN Technologies (formerly Huawei Marine Networks), and infrastructure conglomerate Hengtong Group, has systematically embedded Chinese-built, Chinese-owned, and Chinese-maintained fiber-optic infrastructure across Africa, from landing stations in Djibouti and Kenya to overland networks serving landlocked nations.

The PEACE cable, the DARE1 system, and the emerging EMA project together form not a commercial telecom play but a deliberate architecture of data positioning: one that gives Beijing persistent access to traffic routing decisions, physical infrastructure, and the repair vessels that keep the network alive.

This paper examines the full stack of China's fiber footprint in Africa, the cables, the landing stations, the data centers built to host sovereign government data, and the intelligence implications for the 54 nations now partially or wholly dependent on Chinese-built digital infrastructure. It concludes with a sovereign infrastructure framework for African governments and strategic recommendations for investors in the African compute space.

I. The Ocean Floor as Strategic Terrain

Subsea cables are among the most invisible and most consequential pieces of infrastructure on Earth. Approximately 600 cable systems, covering 1.2 million kilometers of ocean floor, carry 99% of all international internet traffic, including an estimated $10 trillion in daily financial transfers. Every email, every cloud workload, every military communication that crosses an ocean travels through a cable system owned by a handful of entities, operated from a handful of landing stations, and repaired by a handful of specialized ships.

For most of the internet's history, those entities were Western: SubCom (United States), Alcatel Submarine Networks (France), and NEC (Japan) collectively held an 87% market share as recently as 2021. The fourth player, HMN Technologies, previously known as Huawei Marine Networks, entered the market in 2008 as a joint venture between Huawei and the UK's Global Marine Systems. It has since become the world's fastest-growing submarine cable manufacturer and layer, according to TeleGeography data, with involvement in over 90 international cable projects.

KEY FINDING

Subsea cables are not neutral commercial infrastructure. They are a surveillance gold mine, and whoever builds, owns, operates, and repairs them controls what data can be seen, rerouted, or disrupted. China has spent fifteen years positioning itself to do all four across Africa.

What makes China's fiber strategy in Africa categorically different from its 5G rollout in European or Asian markets is the absence of pushback. The US successfully blocked HMN Technologies from building the SeaMeWe-6 cable connecting Southeast Asia to Europe, pouring millions in training grants into foreign telecoms to flip the contract to SubCom. It intervened in at least six cable deals across the Asia-Pacific. It blocked Google, Meta, and Amazon from landing cables in Hong Kong. None of those interventions have counterparts in Africa. On the continent where the cable gap is most acute, Chinese infrastructure has filled the void, and filled it comprehensively.

II. Cable Architecture: PEACE, DARE, & the Network Taking Shape

2.1 The PEACE Cable: The BRI's Digital Spine

The Pakistan and East Africa Connecting Europe (PEACE) cable is the single most important Chinese infrastructure project in the African connectivity landscape. Funded, owned, and constructed entirely by Chinese entities, it was built to complement the Belt and Road Initiative physically, connecting China's $62 billion China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) in Gwadar, Pakistan, to Djibouti (where China maintains its only overseas naval base), to Kenya and Egypt,

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terminating in Marseille, France. The cable is owned by Peace Cable International Network, a subsidiary of Hengtong Group. The equipment was supplied by HMN Technologies. The 15,000-kilometer system entered full commercial service in December 2022, operating on WSS ROADM technology with a design capacity of 24 Tbit/s per fiber pair. A second phase extends the cable to Singapore and South Africa, deepening its geographic footprint across the Indian Ocean rim.

15,000	24 Tb/s	7	2022
Cable Length (km)	**Design Capacity**	**African Landing Points**	**Operational Since**
Phase 1 deployment	Per fiber pair	Including Djibouti, Kenya, Egypt	Full commercial service

The routing logic of PEACE is not commercially neutral. It bypasses India, a strategic competitor to both China and Pakistan, entirely. Its first African stop is Djibouti, which hosts a Chinese naval base and serves as the anchor point for Chinese logistics in the Horn of Africa. Every routing decision in the PEACE system was made by entities whose interests align with Beijing's geopolitical priorities, not with the bandwidth optimization needs of the African nations the cable nominally serves.

> **ATLANTIC COUNCIL FINDING**
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> *The PEACE cable was built specifically to complement the BRI, connecting Chinese assets in Gwadar, Pakistan, to Djibouti (host of China's overseas naval base), and running through Africa's most strategically sensitive coastal zones before arriving in Europe. Each touchpoint is situated in a region of critical geopolitical significance.*

2.2 DARE1 and the East African Corridor

The DARE1 cable, Digital Africa Reaching Europe 1, expanded the Chinese fiber footprint along East Africa's coast, adding connectivity to Djibouti, Somalia, and Tanzania. The cable was completed and entered service in 2024, extending Chinese cable architecture deeper into the Horn of Africa and into the southern Swahili coast. China Mobile International, one of Beijing's three state-owned telecom carriers, participated as a key backer and commissioned the core infrastructure segments of 2Africa, the 37,000-kilometer system that encircles the African continent, integrating Chinese state carrier capacity into a project formally led by a Western consortium.

The 2Africa integration is instructive. China Mobile International optimized resource allocation along the Arabian Sea, the eastern and western coasts of Africa, and created explicit synergies

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with the PEACE cable, effectively linking two cable systems under partial Chinese operational influence into a coordinated network. From Djibouti, Tanzania, Kenya, South Africa, and Nigeria, CMI's traffic routing decisions now shape connectivity for hundreds of millions of users.

2.3 The EMA Project: China's Direct Rival to Western Connectivity

Following the US government's successful campaign to award the SeaMeWe-6 contract to SubCom rather than HMN Technologies, China's three state carriers, China Mobile, China Telecom, and China Unicom, initiated the Europe-Middle East-Asia (EMA) cable project. The EMA cable links Hong Kong through Singapore, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, Egypt, and France, a near-identical route to SeaMeWe-6, but under full Chinese ownership.

The EMA project is the clearest evidence that China's submarine cable strategy is not primarily commercial. When blocked from participation in Western-led consortia, Beijing did not withdraw from the market, it built a parallel one. The US Commerce Department sanctioned HMN Technologies in December 2021, alleging the company intended to acquire American technology to support China's People's Liberation Army. That sanction made it impossible for owners of HMN-built cables to sell bandwidth to US tech firms, typically the largest customers. China's response was to construct a cable ecosystem that does not need US customers.

JUSTIN SHERMAN, ATLANTIC COUNCIL CYBER STATECRAFT INITIATIVE

Undersea cables are a surveillance gold mine for the world's intelligence agencies. When we talk about US-China tech competition, when we talk about espionage and the capture of data, submarine cables are involved in every aspect of those rising geopolitical tensions.

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III. The Intelligence Architecture: What Cable Ownership Actually Means

3.1 Access Points, Landing Stations, and the Surveillance Premium

The national security concern with Chinese cable infrastructure is not theoretical. Spy agencies, all of them, including American ones, tap into cables at landing stations on their territory. This is not a hypothetical capability; it is a documented and well-understood feature of how signals intelligence has operated since the telegraph era. The question is not whether cables can be tapped, but who controls the tap.

When HMN Technologies builds a cable, Chinese engineers design the repeaters, amplifiers, and branching units embedded along its length, the physical equipment through which all data must pass. When Hengtong Group operates the cable, Chinese personnel manage the network operations center that determines routing decisions. When Chinese repair ships service a cut or fault, Chinese technicians have physical access to the cable at sea, at points that may be thousands of kilometers from any landing station and outside the jurisdiction of any coastal state.

> **US SENATE TESTIMONY FINDING**
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> *It is difficult to imagine a scenario in which the Chinese government, with its legal and extralegal ability to coerce technology companies, would not consider placing specific pressure on submarine cable companies, or even individuals at those companies, to assist with tapping into or otherwise compromising that infrastructure for its own advantage.*

The repair ship dimension is particularly underexamined. Chinese cable repair firm S.B. Submarine Systems (SBSS) has repaired cables owned by US companies. Its vessels have been documented turning off their transponders at sea, hiding their locations from radio and satellite tracking, while traveling through strategically sensitive waters around Singapore, Hong Kong, the Yellow Sea, and Taiwan. A cable repair visit is indistinguishable, from the outside, from a cable intelligence operation.

3.2 The Djibouti Node: Where Naval and Digital Strategy Converge

Djibouti is the single most important node in China's African data intelligence architecture, and it is no accident that it is also home to China's only overseas military base. The PEACE cable's first African landing point is Djibouti. China has invested heavily in Djibouti's port infrastructure under BRI. The Doraleh Multipurpose Port, built and operated by China Merchants Group, sits adjacent to the cable landing station, giving Chinese entities physical proximity to both the maritime entry point for Gulf shipping and the terrestrial entry point for Africa-Europe internet traffic.

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This convergence of naval basing, port control, and cable landing station is not coincidental. It is the structural expression of a doctrine that treats data infrastructure and military infrastructure as components of the same strategic system. For African governments that have welcomed Chinese investment in Djibouti as economic development, the intelligence implications of this convergence are rarely surfaced in the bilateral conversations that approved it.

13	18%	6	0
Chinese-Built MENA Cables	**HMN Global Cable Share**	**US Interventions Blocked**	**Africa Interventions Blocked**
Owned, constructed, or upgraded	By total length laid, past 4 years	Asia-Pacific deals, 2019–2023	US has not intervened in African deals

3.3 The Repair Ship as Intelligence Asset

Of the four companies that manufacture and lay 98% of the world's subsea cables, only HMN Technologies is subject to the legal and extralegal authority of a government, China's, that has both the intent and the capability to use commercial infrastructure for intelligence collection. This is the distinction that the US government has consistently articulated in its interventions in Asia-Pacific cable deals but has failed to operationalize in Africa.

Beyond HMN Technologies, Chinese entities have expanded into the cable repair market, a segment that gives even greater, more persistent, and less visible access to cable infrastructure than the original build. A cable repair visit requires physical access to the cable at sea, at the specific point of fault, with equipment that can be connected to the cable's internal structure. The repair ship becomes, functionally, an intelligence collection platform.

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IV. The Full Stack: Data Centers, 5G, and the Tech Stack Lock-In

4.1 Huawei's Dominance of African Wireless Infrastructure

The submarine cable strategy does not operate in isolation. It is the undersea layer of a comprehensive digital stack that China has methodically deployed across Africa. At the wireless layer, Huawei equipment accounts for nearly 70% of 4G infrastructure across the African continent. Huawei was the first company to offer 5G services in Africa, with commercial networks live in South Africa and Kenya, and trials ongoing across multiple additional markets.

This wireless dominance matters for the cable intelligence thesis in a direct way: the data that flows through a Chinese-built submarine cable originates, in many African markets, on a Chinese-built cellular network, passes through a Chinese-built base station, traverses a Chinese-managed terrestrial fiber connection to a Chinese-operated landing station, and exits Africa through a Chinese-manufactured cable. The entire data pathway, from device to global internet, can be subject to Chinese access at multiple points simultaneously.

> **CNAS FINDING, 2025**
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> *Chinese dominance in telecom equipment gives Beijing sustained leverage over countries' communications systems. Its expanding smart city programs and surveillance networks across Africa and Latin America have raised global concerns about data integrity and privacy. Awareness has grown in Washington, but strategy and resources remain lacking.*

4.2 Government Data Centers: The Senegal Model

The cable and wireless infrastructure is the delivery mechanism. The data center is where Chinese influence on African sovereign data becomes most acute. At the 2021 Forum on China-Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) in Dakar, Senegal, China announced a $79 million government-funded data center to host Senegal's national digital platforms, moving the country's sovereign data from servers in the United States and Europe to a Huawei-built, Chinese government-financed facility on Senegalese soil.

President Macky Sall framed the move as a boost to Senegal's digital sovereignty. The framing was not inaccurate on its surface, data physically located in Senegal is, in principle, more accessible to the Senegalese government than data on servers in Virginia. But the equipment in that data center was built by Huawei. The loan that financed it was issued by the Chinese government. And the technical staff trained to operate it were trained by Huawei personnel. Digital sovereignty, in this model, is sovereignty from American infrastructure, achieved by replacing that dependency with a Chinese one.

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Huawei has built or supplied data centers across Zambia, Zimbabwe, Tanzania, Togo, Mali, Madagascar, and Mozambique using similar financing and equipment models. In each case, the host government receives infrastructure it could not otherwise afford; in each case, the infrastructure runs on Chinese equipment, trained by Chinese personnel, under loan conditions that create long-term financial dependency.

TATARI INSTITUTE RESEARCH POSITION

A data center built by Huawei, financed by a Chinese government loan, operated by Huawei-trained personnel, and connected to the internet via an HMN-built submarine cable is not sovereign infrastructure. It is a Chinese data architecture with a local address.

4.3 Standards, Norms, and the Rules of the Digital Road

Beyond hardware, China's Digital Silk Road is a normative project. Beijing has signed digital cooperation agreements with at least 16 African countries, and the actual number is almost certainly higher, as many memoranda of understanding go unreported. Through these agreements, China promotes Chinese technical standards, Chinese data governance frameworks, and Chinese models of internet regulation that prioritize state control over data flows. The 2008 Chinese foreign aid law stated explicitly that recipients of Chinese foreign aid must adopt Chinese standards to qualify. The DSR Bluebook published by Fudan University in 2018 identified five application areas for core DSR technologies: infrastructure, trade, finance, 'people's hearts,' and policy, the last two representing information environment shaping and regulatory alignment. African nations that adopt Chinese technical standards in 5G and submarine cables become embedded in a Chinese technology ecosystem that is difficult to exit.

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V. The US Response: Effective in Asia, Absent in Africa

The contrast between US cable policy in the Asia-Pacific and in Africa is stark and consequential. In Asia, the US government intervened in at least six cable deals to block HMN Technologies from winning contracts. It issued commerce sanctions against HMN in December 2021 that effectively made Chinese-built cables incompatible with US hyperscaler bandwidth sales. It provided training grants to foreign telecoms conditioned on choosing SubCom over HMN. It successfully rerouted the SeaMeWe-6 contract to an American company despite HMN Technologies having been on the brink of winning the business.

None of these interventions have a counterpart in Africa. The PEACE cable was never subject to a US campaign to redirect its construction to a non-Chinese provider. The Djibouti landing station was never the subject of a diplomatic effort to ensure non-Chinese operational control. The Senegal data center was never met with a competing US offer. The CNAS assessment published in late 2025 was explicit: despite growing awareness of the DSR's strategic implications, US strategy and resources remain lacking, with successes like helping Costa Rica replace Huawei networks representing the exception, not the rule.

> **CNAS, COUNTERING THE DIGITAL SILK ROAD, 2025**
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> *Huawei now operates in over 170 countries and leads the global telecommunications equipment market. Countering the DSR is not about rejecting all Chinese technology, but about addressing where its spread threatens US national security and allied interests. Washington's current response falls systematically short of what the scale of Chinese investment demands.*

The asymmetry has a structural explanation. US cable intervention policy is primarily exercised through the FCC's Team Telecom process, which reviews foreign participation in cables landing on US territory or connecting to US-owned entities. Africa has almost no cables landing on US territory and almost no cable projects requiring US regulatory approval. The legal and institutional mechanism that blocks Chinese cable dominance in the Asia-Pacific simply does not apply to the African market, and no alternative mechanism has been created to fill the gap.

VI. Implications for African Governments and AI Investors

6.1 The Dependency Trap in Practice

African governments face a genuine dilemma. The continent's infrastructure financing gap is projected to approach $15 trillion by 2040. Chinese entities offer cable construction, data center development, and 5G network deployment at prices, on timelines, and with financing structures that no Western alternative currently matches. The Partnership for Global Infrastructure and

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Investment (PGII), the EU's Global Gateway, and Japan's ODA have advanced parallel but chronically underfunded and uncoordinated agendas. In the absence of a credible alternative, Chinese infrastructure is not merely an option, it is often the only option. But the dependency created by accepting Chinese infrastructure is not simply financial. It is operational and intelligence-related. A government whose national data transits Chinese-built cables, sits in Chinese-built data centers, and traverses Chinese-built cellular networks has, in effect, granted Beijing persistent access to its information environment, not as a matter of legal agreement, but as a structural consequence of the technical architecture it has adopted.

6.2 The Iran Conflict's Relevance: When Infrastructure Becomes a Lever

The US-Iran conflict that erupted in February 2026, and the resulting drone strikes on AWS data centers in the UAE and Bahrain, provided a live demonstration of how data infrastructure can be weaponized. Iran struck AWS facilities because they hosted US military intelligence workloads. The same logic applies to Chinese cable infrastructure in Africa: a government whose telecommunications passes through Chinese cables has implicitly accepted that those cables are subject to routing decisions, access requests, and potentially physical disruption based on Beijing's geopolitical calculations. The US-Iran war also accelerated Gulf states' race to build overland fiber alternatives to compromised maritime routes, a race driven by the sudden recognition that submarine cable chokepoints are not commercially neutral. African governments watching that scramble should draw the obvious lesson: the time to build alternative routing and domestically anchored infrastructure is before a crisis, not during one.

STRATEGIC IMPLICATION

For African governments currently dependent on Chinese-built cables and data centers, the relevant question is not whether Chinese infrastructure offers good value. It does. The question is what Beijing can do with the access that infrastructure provides, and whether that access is visible, negotiable, or subject to African sovereign control at all.

6.3 What This Means for the African Compute Investment Thesis

For investors in African digital infrastructure, including those building data center, GPU compute, and AI inference capacity on the continent, China's fiber footprint creates both a risk and an opportunity. The risk is that African AI infrastructure built to serve sovereign or enterprise clients may sit on top of Chinese-controlled connectivity, limiting the data sovereignty claims that underpin the premium positioning of African compute relative to Gulf hyperscalers. The opportunity is that the gap between African governments' stated data sovereignty goals and the Chinese-infrastructure reality they are currently living creates a structural demand for genuinely sovereign, non-aligned compute infrastructure.

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VII. Strategic Recommendations

The following recommendations address African governments, technology investors, and multilateral development institutions.

For African Governments

- **Conduct a full-stack audit of national data infrastructure:** Map every layer of your government's data environment, from mobile networks to terrestrial fiber to landing stations to international cables, and identify which components are Chinese-built, Chinese-financed, or Chinese-maintained. Most governments have never done this exercise. Most would find the answer alarming.
- **Negotiate infrastructure agreements with explicit intelligence carve-outs:** Any cable landing agreement, data center financing arrangement, or telecom equipment contract with a Chinese entity should include provisions specifying that the host government retains the right to audit physical access to the infrastructure, inspect repair vessel operations in its territorial waters, and require that any government data transiting the cable be encrypted end-to-end before leaving national jurisdiction.
- **Build overland routing redundancy before the crisis:** The Gulf states' scramble to build overland fiber corridors after the Hormuz closure is a costly lesson in crisis-driven infrastructure planning. East African governments should establish overland fiber redundancy through intra-African cable systems, particularly the pan-African networks linking the East African Community, before a conflict or cable cut forces the issue.
- **Diversify landing station control:** Djibouti's near-total Chinese infrastructure footprint should not be replicated. African governments negotiating new cable landing agreements should prioritize multi-party governance of landing stations, with explicit provisions preventing any single foreign entity from controlling physical access to the station.

For Technology Investors and AI Infrastructure Developers

- **Price Chinese infrastructure dependency into risk models:** Any data center investment in Africa that relies on Chinese-built connectivity for international transit should model the scenario in which that connectivity is subject to routing disruption, access demands, or physical interference as a function of Beijing's geopolitical posture, not as a tail risk, but as a baseline operating assumption.
- **Build the sovereign stack from the ground up:** The most defensible positioning for African AI infrastructure investment is full-stack sovereignty: domestic power, domestic fiber to the landing station, non-Chinese cable systems for international connectivity, and non-Chinese equipment in the data center. This stack costs more to build. It also commands a price premium from the governments and enterprises whose data sovereignty requirements make Chinese infrastructure unacceptable.

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- **Engage multilateral development finance early:** The PGII, EU Global Gateway, and IFC all have mandates to fund non-Chinese digital infrastructure in Africa but chronic execution gaps. First-mover investors who bring shovel-ready, sovereign-stack projects to these institutions can access concessional capital that dramatically improves economics relative to going to market with commercial financing alone.

For Multilateral Development Institutions

- **Match the speed and scale of Chinese financing:** China's infrastructure financing advantage in Africa is not primarily about price, it is about speed, simplicity, and the absence of the conditionality and procurement delays that characterize Western development finance. Closing the gap requires streamlined approval processes, pre-negotiated equipment standards, and dedicated facilities for digital infrastructure that do not route through the same multi-year pipelines as energy or transportation projects.
- **Fund cable system alternatives explicitly:** The International Technology Security and Innovation Fund (ITSI) and similar US programs have made a start in funding non-Chinese connectivity in specific markets. These need to be scaled by an order of magnitude, with explicit Africa mandates and pre-approved framework agreements that allow individual country deals to close within 90 days rather than several years.

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VIII. Conclusion

The contest for control of Africa's digital infrastructure is not a future scenario. It is a present reality, and by most measures, China is winning it. HMN Technologies has laid cable in over 90 international projects worldwide. Huawei equipment powers nearly 70% of Africa's 4G networks and is embedded in the continent's first 5G deployments. Chinese government loans finance data centers that host sovereign African government data on Chinese-built hardware. And not one of the US interventions that successfully redirected cable contracts away from Chinese entities in the Asia-Pacific has a counterpart on the African continent. The strategic logic of China's fiber footprint in Africa is not commercial. It is architectural. Beijing is building the physical infrastructure through which African governments, African enterprises, and eventually African AI systems will communicate with the world, and doing so at the layer of the stack that is most invisible, most persistent, and most difficult to exit. A government can switch smartphone brands. It cannot easily reroute the submarine cable that connects it to the global internet. For the Tatari Institute's research and investment mandate, this analysis reinforces a core strategic conviction: the most durable competitive advantage in African AI infrastructure is not scale or capital, it is verifiable sovereignty. In a world where Chinese cables carry African government data, where Chinese data centers host African national platforms, and where Chinese repair ships service the cables that connect Africa to the globe, there is growing and unmet demand for infrastructure that is genuinely owned, genuinely controlled, and genuinely auditable by the nations it serves. The fiber is already on the ocean floor. The question is who reads what flows through it.

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